

Business-class Cell Phones

O2 Xda Atom

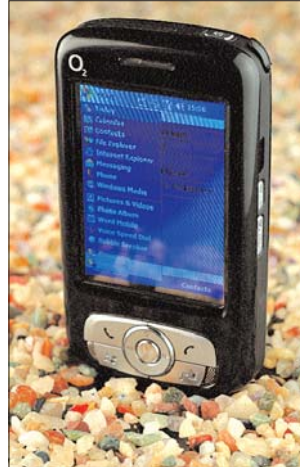
"Small but loaded"

The hot new Xda Atom from O2 is a PDA phone that packs in loads of features in an extremely small form factor. Measuring an impressive 58 x 102 x 18.5 mm and weighing just 140 gms, the Atom is a tad smaller than its predecessor, the highly successful Xda II Mini.

Encased in an elegant piano black casing, the Atom sports a 2.7-inch screen. The fascia sports large send and end keys, a 5-way navigation pad, and keys assigned to the Start Menu and the MediaPlus application, along with two tiny speakers. There are two volume keys on the left, voice recorder and camera keys on the right, and a power button on top. The camera lens, the self-portrait mirror and flash are located on the rear while the bottom is where you will find the USB connector, the headphone socket and the reset button. While Windows Mobile 5.0 implements softkeys to enhance one-handed operation, the Atom, unfortunately, does not come with dedicated softkeys.

Powered by an Intel PXA272 processor running at 416 MHz, the Atom comes with 128 MB of ROM and 64 MB of RAM. You can add more memory by using the mini-SD slot located on top. The 2.7-inch touch-screen supports 262K colours at a resolution of 240 x 320. Connectivity options include triband, GPRS/EDGE, infrared, Bluetooth 1.2 and WiFi 802.11b. The camera is a 2 megapixel CMOS that can capture both stills and video. Other goodies include an FM tuner, strobe flash and a bundled stereo wired headset. You can even record from FM in WAV or AMR formats. The device synchronises with a PC via a USB cable.

The Atom runs the new Windows Mobile 5.0 operating system, the most notable feature of which, in our opinion, is persistent storage. This means this phone will not lose any data or



O2 Xda Atom - Powerhouse in your pocket

installed programs when you run out of battery power. Office applications (Word Mobile, Excel Mobile and PowerPoint Mobile) now support embedded images, charts and tables. Standard PIM applications such as Calendar, Tasks and Notes are all there. All data can be easily synchronised with your PC. O2 has thrown in a few of their own applications, including the O2 MediaPlus, SMS Plus and Equalizer. MediaPlus lets you play and view various media—radio, music, pictures and video, from a single window. O2 SMS Plus lets you view your text messages in an instant messaging format. The O2 Connect application informs you of system updates. The Setup Wizard combines a number of otherwise scattered settings in one place, helping you get started in a jiffy. Apart from these, you also get an Auto Configurator, a photo editing application and a self-diagnostic tool.

The glossy casing attracts fingerprints and dust, so you may end up spending a lot of time cleaning your phone. The 416 MHz processor is capable of running most applications and games with ease and lets you multitask. The new OS still retains the nagging "Smart Minimise" feature that does not close applications even when you tap on the close button. However, this can be easily circumvented by using a task manager such as SPB Pocket Plus or SmallMenu (or using the Memory module in Settings to shut down applications manually). Phone clarity is good, even in areas with low network coverage. You can use the speakerphone in a noisy environment. WiFi and Bluetooth also work well.

The stylus is a bit skinny and the touch-screen too sensitive. You can use the virtual keyboard or handwriting recognition to input text. However, due to the screen size, the virtual keyboard is quite small. The screen display is vibrant, but visibility is reduced under sunlight. The camera application is slow to use, and does not redeem itself with

The Nokia 7370

Lifestyle Phones

Nokia wanted in the flip-phone category, the love that Samsung and Motorola seem to be wallowing in. The 7370 is an entry for the lifestyle segment. It tries to shake off the 'rugged and utilitarian' impressions that Nokia has, with a swivel display that rotates 180 degrees in both directions! Alas, it cannot do a complete 360.

A rather unusual brown is used to colour the 7370. This in itself makes the phone stand out in the crowd of blacks and silvers. Being a phone that is made to please, the display quality is good with a 262K colour screen. A nice white backlit keypad offers a clear viewing of the keys in the night and looking graceful at the same time.

Keeping costs low means no expandable memory—you will have to make do with a 10 MB internal memory. Not good enough, considering its 1.3 megapixel camera whose high resolution photo can be as big as 400 KB each. 20 of such images would occupy about 8 MB which is how much you will have left after SMS, Phonebook and call logs take up

their share.

As the display slides 180 degrees both ways, the screen re-orient itself. A minor irritant is that when the screen is closed, the name 'Nokia' appears in reverse direction of the display. Rather silly, we think.

A slide type phone with bold keys and large display along with a curvy design with soft white keypad light makes the phone, in our opinion gender neutral. If your decision boils down to a phone with good build quality and off beat looks coupled with functionality, 7370 is a nice, fast phone for you. And, it does not cost the earth either.

+ Good display quality, easy navigation
- Only 10 MB internal memory
Rating: 3.5/5

